

EYEWITNESS December 1862/January 1863

The Battle of Stones River

With orders to strike the Confederate encampment, General William S. Rosecrans advanced toward Murfreesboro. At dawn on December 31, General Braxton Bragg launched the Rebel attack, driving back the Union line. After marking time on New Year's Day, Bragg attacked again on January 2, forcing Union troops back across the river. The Northerners retaliated with artillery fire and the Rebels retreated.

“The battle of Stone’s River, Tennessee, on the 31st of December, 1862, and the 2nd of January, 1863, was one of the most fiercely contested and bloody conflicts of the war ... I do not think that two better armies, as numerous and so nearly matched in strength, ever met in battle ...

Before this battle I had been inclined to underrate the importance of artillery ... but I never knew that arm to render such important service as at this point. The sound judgment, bravery, and skill of Major John Mendenhall, who was my chief of artillery, enabled me to open 58 guns almost simultaneously on Breckinridge’s men and to turn a dashing charge into a sudden retreat and rout ... I witnessed the effect of this cannonade upon the Confederate advance ... The very forest seemed to fall before our fire, and not a Confederate reached the river.”

LIEUTENANT COLONEL G. C. KNIFFIN, ON THE STAFF OF UNION GENERAL THOMAS L. CRITTENDEN AT STONES RIVER, IN *BATTLES & LEADERS OF THE CIVIL WAR*, 1887

“The Confederate brigades, now melted to three-fourths their original numbers, wavered and fell back; again and again they re-formed in the woods and advanced to the charge, only to meet with a bloody repulse. All along the line from Harker’s right to Wood’s left, the space gradually narrowed between the contending hosts. The weak had gone to the rear; there was no room now for any but brave men, and no time given for new dispositions; every man who had a stomach for fighting was engaged on the front line ...